

Chapter 141-1

Yan Lin stood to the side, sizing up Liang Shi. The surprise in her eyes was impossible to hide. She probably never expected that Zhu Mingqi would let someone she was meeting for the first time call her "Auntie."

For many people, this was a relationship they couldn't establish no matter how hard they tried.

Zhu Mingqi wasn't this warm to just anyone.

Especially not to someone she was meeting for the first time.

This made Yan Lin feel it was extraordinary.

However, Zhu Mingqi ignored her reaction and continued speaking to Liang Shi: "Miss Liang, please continue enjoying the exhibition. Thank you for today."

Liang Shi nodded: "Alright."

After that, Zhu Mingqi and Yan Lin turned and left.

She stood in place watching for a moment, and couldn't help but marvel once again—Auntie Zhu's poise was truly excellent, much better than many celebrities.

Before this, Liang Shi had thought the person with the best poise was Yang Jiani.

Because Yang Jiani came from a traditional opera background, her bearing and deportment had always been exceptionally maintained.

Even though her gaze was always somewhat sinister, there was no denying her poise.

Not just anyone could wear a qipao¹ with such elegance.

Yet Auntie Zhu's poise was even better than Yang Jiani's by several degrees.

Moreover, as someone in a position of power, she didn't carry any condescending air at all. Talking with her felt very comfortable.

Most importantly, Liang Shi kept feeling that she looked very familiar.

She didn't know where she had seen her before.

It wasn't until she went downstairs that Liang Shi suddenly realized—that Auntie Zhu looked somewhat like Shen Hui, especially the mouth.

No wonder... Yan Lin had called her "Bomu."²

Everything made sense now.

However, Liang Shi was only guessing and wasn't certain.

Footnotes:

¹ **Qipao** (旗袍): Also known as cheongsam, this is a traditional Chinese dress characterized by its form-fitting silhouette, high collar, and side slits. It requires excellent posture and bearing to wear elegantly.

² **Bomu** (伯母): A respectful term of address meaning "aunt" or "auntie," specifically used to address the wife of one's father's elder brother, or more broadly, an older woman of one's parents' generation who holds a higher social status. The fact that Yan Lin uses this term suggests Zhu Mingqi is likely the mother of someone Yan Lin knows well—in this case, Shen Hui.

Chapter 141-2

//

Meanwhile, on the other side, Yan Lin was carrying Zhu Mingqi's bag. Zhu Mingqi asked her: "A-Hui¹ still hasn't come?"

"She has something going on at the hospital." Yan Lin bent slightly at the waist, appearing respectful. "It's peak flu season right now, and they can't leave the hospital."

Zhu Mingqi paused, then sighed helplessly: "Why are you still covering for her?"

Yan Lin smiled: "Bomu, I'm really not. A-Hui truly does have something going on."

Zhu Mingqi shot her a sidelong glance: "She came out of my belly—how could I not know her? She definitely doesn't want to come because she thinks I'm trying to set you two up again."

Yan Lin said helplessly: "You've got it wrong there. A-Hui really doesn't mind that kind of thing."

Zhu Mingqi scoffed lightly, "If you ask me, she just hasn't gotten over that... what's her name again?"

Yan Lin reminded her: "Zhao Xuning."

"Right, her." Zhu Mingqi said: "I don't know what's so good about her that she had A-Hui so captivated. If I'd known, I wouldn't have let her study medicine back then. She should have studied finance like you, then she could help share Fenghe's burden."

Yan Lin spoke up for Shen Hui: "They dated in university, and she was A-Hui's first love. Of course she can't let go."

"That's just because she hasn't found someone better." Zhu Mingqi said: "I advised her back then—if you like her, don't break up. But she insisted on breaking up, and after breaking up she won't look for anyone else. I really can't understand you young people."

Yan Lin: "..."

Zhu Mingqi said while looking at the paintings: "It's like these paintings—I'm becoming unable to appreciate them too."

Yan Lin said: "These are all painters that the new generation of young people are particularly fond of."

"Indeed." Zhu Mingqi said: "Trends come and go in waves. Our wave has already passed."

Yan Lin was an honest person who wasn't very good at flattery, so she just listened quietly.

After a while, Yan Lin couldn't suppress her curiosity any longer and asked: "Bomu, do you know that person from earlier?"

Zhu Mingqi happened to stop in front of Chen Mian's painting and first remarked: "This painting is quite distinctive."

"You mean Liang Shi?" Zhu Mingqi then asked.

Yan Lin nodded: "Yes."

"It's the first time I've met her." Zhu Mingqi said: "But she's quite pretty. Doesn't my A-Hui like good-looking people? Especially her eyes—they're quite similar to my eldest's, right? She even has a bit of a couple's look with A-Hui. I thought I could introduce her to my A-Hui. Maybe A-Hui could forget about that what's-her-name Ning."

"Zhao Xuning." Yan Lin reminded her again.

"Mm-hmm, I can never remember that girl's name." Zhu Mingqi said: "But I remember that face. She really is quite pretty—no wonder my A-Hui likes her."

Yan Lin remained silent at the side, secretly sending Shen Hui a message: 【If you don't come soon, your mom is going to marry you off.】

This action was noticed by Zhu Mingqi, who warned in a low voice: "Don't you go tipping off Shen Hui. It's just a thought—I haven't acted on it."

Yan Lin put away her phone and immediately said: "I wasn't..."

"That young lady is already married." Zhu Mingqi said, somewhat disappointed. "My A-Hui doesn't have that fortune."

Yan Lin gave a light cough. "I'm still here, you know."

"Don't think I don't know." Zhu Mingqi gave her a look. "You and A-Hui are just teaming up to deceive us. But feelings—those can't be faked."

Yan Lin: "..."

"If you like someone, even if you cover your mouth, it will show through your eyes." Zhu Mingqi laughed at her: "You and A-Hui each have someone you like. You two are so familiar with each other, yet there's not a shred of romantic feeling between you. It's impossible for it to work out, so of course I have to find someone else for my A-Hui."

Yan Lin: "..."

Yan Lin smiled awkwardly: "You really understand these things."

"Of course." Zhu Mingqi said: "I was someone who dated when I was young too."

"I never would have thought Uncle Shen was so romantic when he was young." Yan Lin teased her: "Your relationship has been this good for decades."

"It wasn't with him." Zhu Mingqi stood in front of Chen Mian's painting without leaving, then finally said: "Let's buy this painting. I'll hang it in the study when I get home."

"Alright." Yan Lin said.

Zhu Mingqi continued from where she left off: "Your Uncle Shen is someone who has been wooden and dull for decades. Like a fool—rigid and boring."

Yan Lin: "..."

"Isn't my eldest exactly like him? Such a fine young lady, and she's already engaged." Zhu Mingqi sighed again when mentioning this. "She doesn't even contact her fiancée. She's an Alpha—why can't she be more proactive? Those two having a meal together every few days only happens because I have someone make the reservations. No wonder the young lady from the Gu family doesn't want to marry her and keeps delaying."

Yan Lin couldn't comment on these matters.

Although Zhu Mingqi was very easygoing, she was still Madam Shen.

Everyone in Haizhou City knew that the Shen and Gu families were the two titans—existences that stood shoulder to shoulder.

The Yan family was beneath these two families.

If it weren't for her close friendship with Shen Hui, she wouldn't have had the opportunity to accompany Zhu Mingqi to an art exhibition like this.

The Shen family members all had good character and would never look down on others. They would even give a helping hand to those they liked.

It was purely based on the other person's character.

But Yan Lin couldn't lack self-awareness.

The marriage alliance between the Shen and Gu families wasn't something she could comment on.

Yan Lin naturally remained silent.

Zhu Mingqi was just venting to her: "Look at that young lady—she looks even younger than A-Hui, yet she's already married. I didn't even dare to ask more, afraid that she might already be holding a baby. As for my two... no, three."

Zhu Mingqi laughed. "Siyan is so quiet at home that I always forget about him. He's about to graduate soon too. Such a wonderful age, and he's handsome too, but he won't properly date anyone. All he does is study all day—exactly like his father. So annoying."

Yan Lin smiled: "Siyan also wants to lighten the burden for Sister Fenghe. After all, A-Hui is willful."

"That's true." Zhu Mingqi said: "A-Hui takes after me—willful. But I'm much more attentive than her. How come she didn't inherit any of that?"

Yan Lin shrugged: "That I don't know."

The two chatted here for a while. Before long, Zhu Mingqi looked into the distance and her expression changed, the smile completely fading from her face.

The person in the distance also cast their gaze over.

Their eyes met.

After a moment, Zhu Mingqi was the first to look away. "Yan Lin, let's go."

Yan Lin was startled: "Bomu, you're not going to keep looking?"

"No." Zhu Mingqi said: "I've run into someone I dislike. If we don't leave, we'll end up arguing soon."

Yan Lin looked around and noticed that not far away, there was a woman in a white long dress glaring fiercely in their direction.

She was a woman about the same age as Zhu Mingqi, but not as well-maintained—she looked somewhat sickly.

"Alright." Yan Lin followed Zhu Mingqi's lead. "Then shall I take you to find A-Hui?"

"That works." Zhu Mingqi walked toward the exit, but suddenly changed her mind as she walked. "Never mind, let's go to that hospital."

"Which one?" Yan Lin was confused.

Zhu Mingqi said: "The hospital where that what's-her-name Ning works. Hasn't she already become an attending physician?² And she skipped grades to get there too."

Yan Lin: "..."

"Don't tell Shen Hui." Zhu Mingqi said: "I'll just register for an appointment, treat it as a health checkup, and take a look while I'm at it."

Yan Lin: "..."

She silently put back the phone she had just picked up, and in her heart, lit a candle for Shen Hui.³

Footnotes:

¹ **A-Hui** (阿茴): A familiar/affectionate way to address someone by adding "A-" (阿) before part of their name. Here it refers to Shen Hui.

² **Attending physician/Resident physician** (住院醫師): In Chinese medical hierarchy, this refers to a doctor who has completed their internship and is now a licensed physician working in a hospital. The text mentions she "skipped grades" (跳級), indicating she advanced faster than the typical timeline.

³ **Lit a candle** (點了根蠟): A Chinese internet slang expression meaning to mourn or express sympathy for someone, similar to saying "RIP" or "thoughts and prayers" in English. It comes from the practice of lighting candles for the deceased. Here, Yan Lin is humorously expressing that Shen Hui is in for trouble since her mother is about to go inspect her ex-girlfriend.

Chapter 141-3

//

After Liang Shi went downstairs to find Liang Wanwan, she spotted two people she disliked at the same time she caught sight of Liang Wanwan.

—Qiu Zimin and Liang Xinran.

Qiu Zimin was wearing a white long dress that didn't quite match her temperament, looking rather out of place. Meanwhile, Liang Xinran wore a light blue dress with a pair of silver high heels, actually looking like she had the air of a wealthy young lady.

Liang Wanwan stood across from them with her head lowered, as if she were being scolded.

Liang Shi originally didn't want to go over, but standing on the stairs and watching Liang Wanwan like that, she ultimately went downstairs and called out from not far away: "Wanwan."

Liang Wanwan raised her head, bit her lip, looking somewhat troubled.

Qiu Zimin and Liang Xinran heard the voice and turned around in unison. Liang Shi met their gazes expressionlessly.

"Wanwan, let's go." Liang Shi said.

Liang Wanwan was about to lift her foot when she heard Qiu Zimin say sharply: "Don't you dare."

Liang Wanwan's footsteps retreated again, but her face showed difficulty as she said in a low voice: "Mom, I have something to do, I need to leave first."

"Liang Wanwan." Qiu Zimin also remembered that family scandals shouldn't be aired in public. "Usually when I ask you to come home, you always make excuses about having things to do at school, yet you can accompany someone else to an art exhibition? Are you doing this on purpose? Do you want to make me so angry I die, just like your eldest and second brother?"

"Didn't eldest brother already go back to the company..." Liang Wanwan didn't dare to resist Qiu Zimin much, but she still weakly argued back: "Second brother went back too. How could they be trying to make you..."

"Liang Wanwan!" Qiu Zimin called her name sternly, with a warning tone.

Liang Wanwan immediately fell silent, even trembling with fright.

Watching from not far away, Liang Shi's brows furrowed tightly. Just then, Chen Mian walked over and lightly patted her shoulder: "What's going on?"

"Help me out." Liang Shi grabbed Chen Mian: "Go bring my younger sister over here."

"That one?" Chen Mian tilted her chin toward Liang Wanwan's direction.

"Yes."

"Why don't you go yourself?" Chen Mian asked.

Liang Shi: "...There are reasons I can't speak of."

Chen Mian didn't ask further. Liang Shi said: "I'll treat you to a meal."

Chen Mian raised an eyebrow: "Do I need you to buy me a meal?"

After saying that, she answered herself: "Actually, I haven't figured out where to have lunch yet."

In reality, the organizers here were having a group meal, but Chen Mian didn't want to attend. Such occasions of social pleasantries weren't suited for her.

Chen Mian raised her hand and took off her glasses, revealing those eyes that carried a few degrees of sharpness—utterly indifferent.

She lifted her foot and walked toward Liang Wanwan.

When Liang Wanwan noticed that Chen Mian was coming, her head lowered even more.

She absolutely didn't want Chen Mian to see her looking so pathetic.

But things didn't go as she wished—not only did Chen Mian see her, she was walking right toward her.

Liang Wanwan's hands clenched into fists, her whole body trembling.

Qiu Zimin questioned her with furrowed brows: "Liang Wanwan, do you also want to never come home again, just like your two brothers?"

Liang Wanwan's voice was as faint as a mosquito: "No..."

Liang Xinran said from the side: "Mom, don't be angry. Wanwan is still young, and there's so much going on at school. It's normal not to come home. A girl her age has so much freedom in university."

"Yes, so much freedom at school." Qiu Zimin became even angrier upon hearing this. "So there's no freedom at home, is that it? You're all just following your brothers' example. I can understand your eldest brother protecting that person, but what about you two? You and your second brother are just fence-sitters.¹ Liang Wanwan, have I ever stopped you from doing things at school? But count for yourself—how long has it been since you've come home?"

Liang Wanwan bit her lower lip and said in a low voice: "Mom, please stop talking."

There was a hint of pleading in her tone.

But Qiu Zimin only heard her mosquito-like voice; she didn't catch a single word of what was said.

Qiu Zimin poked her in frustration,² "Is this what I usually teach you? You can't even speak properly anymore? Go ahead and learn from her then—see what you can learn..."

As she spoke, she was about to poke Liang Wanwan's forehead again, but her finger was stopped by someone.

Chen Mian was wearing a loose white dress shirt, with one side tucked into her black dress pants.

Since today was a somewhat important occasion, she had even put on a tie under her white shirt—though like her shirt, it hung loosely.

She was a bit taller than Liang Wanwan, directly blocking Liang Wanwan from the side.

Qiu Zimin had her finger grabbed. She looked up to see someone she didn't recognize, and after a moment of stunned silence, she said coldly: "Who are you?"

"Her friend." Chen Mian said: "In public like this, Auntie, isn't this a bit inappropriate?"

Qiu Zimin frowned and let out a light breath. She didn't want to embarrass herself in public either, but the other person was standing there, using considerable force to bend her finger back—it hurt quite a bit.

It took a great deal of effort to finally pull her finger free. Qiu Zimin shook her finger out. "I'm disciplining my daughter. Even if you're Wanwan's friend, you should know your place."

"Huh?" Chen Mian's genuine astonishment carried a hint of contempt, making it rather uncomfortable to hear.

Qiu Zimin said: "What do you mean by that?"

Chen Mian shrugged. "Nothing really. If you think a friend stopping you from doing this is not knowing her place, then how about girlfriend."

Chen Mian met her gaze, looking extremely arrogant.

Chen Mian curved her lips into a light smile. "I can't stand watching others bully my girlfriend. Your daughter is all grown up now, old enough to have a girlfriend, yet you're still acting like this in public—do you even know how to raise a daughter? I'm glad my girlfriend isn't like you, otherwise I wouldn't dare have children in the future."

Qiu Zimin: "...?"

Chen Mian's words were full of twists and turns, cursing Qiu Zimin in a roundabout way.

Without a single dirty word.

It took Qiu Zimin a while to react. "You..."

But before she could retort and curse back, Chen Mian had already grabbed Liang Wanwan's wrist and walked away from her, swagger and all.

This infuriated Qiu Zimin to no end.

And in that instant, Liang Wanwan, whose wrist was being held by Chen Mian, raised her head to look at her back.

Chen Mian had a slight hunch, not the perfectly straight kind.

But she was tall enough that it didn't affect her posture at all.

Liang Wanwan's palms were damp with sweat as she looked at Chen Mian's back through the misty fog in her eyes.

Footnotes:

¹ **Fence-sitters** (牆頭草): Literally "grass on top of a wall," this is a Chinese idiom describing someone who sways whichever way the wind blows—someone who doesn't take sides or changes their stance based on the situation. Here, Qiu Zimin is accusing Liang Wanwan and her second brother of not being loyal to her.

² **Poked her in frustration** (恨鐵不成鋼地戳了她一下): The phrase "恨鐵不成鋼" literally means "hating iron for not becoming steel." It's an idiom describing the frustration one feels when someone fails to meet expectations or live up to their potential—like being disappointed that iron won't turn into something more valuable like steel. It conveys a mix of anger and disappointment, typically from a parent or mentor toward someone they care about.

Chapter 141-4

//

Chen Mian and Liang Shi met outside the art museum.

Liang Wanwan was in a bad mood, standing to the side without saying a word.

Chen Mian was the first to apologize to Liang Wanwan: "Sorry about that. It was all because your sister asked me to get you out of there that I said those things. I've offended you—don't take it to heart."

Liang Wanwan instantly felt even worse.

The cold winter sun hung in the sky, refracting a frigid light.

Liang Wanwan said timidly: "It's fine."

She kept her head lowered the entire time, not daring to look at Chen Mian even once.

Earlier, when Chen Mian had strode briskly while holding her hand and leading her outside, she had already looked her fill.

That was her most, most, most greedy moment.

Liang Shi gave Chen Mian a thumbs up: "Chen Mian, you're pretty ruthless when you curse people out."

Chen Mian raised an eyebrow and smiled: "It was alright."

Liang Shi had heard everything just now and could deeply relate to those words of Chen Mian's.

The three of them stood outside the art museum, all feeling somewhat cold.

And the one dressed the lightest was Chen Mian.

Chen Mian's coat was made of wool, with just a single dress shirt underneath—it could pass for spring clothing.

Yet she stood in the wind without shivering at all.

Liang Shi couldn't help but reach over and feel the fabric of her coat—it was just a very ordinary kind.

"Aren't you cold?" Liang Shi asked her.

Chen Mian shrugged: "It's alright."

"Your little sister here is scared stiff." Chen Mian glanced at Liang Wanwan. "You should comfort her."

Liang Shi looked toward Liang Wanwan, and Liang Wanwan immediately said: "I'm fine."

Her voice was thick with a nasal tone.

Liang Shi asked instead: "Has Liang Xinran moved back to the old residence again?"

"I don't know." Liang Wanwan sniffled. "I haven't been back for many days now."

Liang Shi: "Alright then."

She didn't ask any more questions. She didn't really want to get involved in the Liang family's affairs.

After standing there for a while, Chen Mian said: "I still have to go do an experience-sharing session. Are you leaving, or will you wait for me a bit?"

"We'll wait for you." Liang Shi said: "I still have to treat you to lunch."

"Alright then, wait in the car." Chen Mian said: "It's cold outside."

Today, Chen Mian had learned a bit of courtesy and etiquette.

Liang Shi acknowledged with a sound.

Chen Mian raised her hand to check her watch and frowned: "This person really isn't punctual."

"Who?" Liang Shi asked.

Chen Mian scoffed lightly: "Qin Lishuang, who else?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Forget it." Chen Mian said: "Can't be bothered to wait for her. I'm going in first."

The moment her words fell, a scornful laugh came from not far away, carrying a hint of mockery: "Master painter Chen, you've truly been waiting a long time."

That slightly shrill voice made Liang Shi's scalp tingle—it was nearly identical to the voice in her memories.

A light laugh, full of contempt.

What would follow was likely a whip coming down, meant to provoke you, to make you angry, to drive you mad, yet leave you powerless to do anything.

And she would be there to admire your helpless state.

Liang Shi turned to look and saw two people.

Qin Lishuang was wearing a form-fitting black dress, her figure gracefully curvaceous. Beside her followed a woman wearing a white baseball cap and a gray tracksuit, with a mask on—it was impossible to see what she looked like.

Upon seeing her, Qin Lishuang let out a light laugh: "Oh my, little Liang Shi is here too."

"What a coincidence." Liang Shi curved her lips, returning the smile in kind.

But there was a hint of cold detachment in that smile.